

PuppyLinux

This is a 90 MB distro that packs quite a punch with numerous utility packages. Download the ISO from www.puppylinux.org/downloads/official-releases/puppy-linux-412 and burn it to a CD.

Boot the live CD, plug in your pen drive and follow these steps:

1. Click **Start→Setup→Puppy universal installer** and choose the USB flash drive install from the wizard that follows. Your pen drive will be detected and you will be presented with a choice of two methods to install Puppy to the USB:
 - A Combo Format method, which creates a 128 MB F16 partition for Puppy system files as well as Pup save configuration files, and a large ext3 partition for data. I found that this method only works if you don't save persistence settings, as the 128 MB size is just too small. I wasn't able to save persistence settings to the ext3 partition.
 - The Super Floppy mode simply takes you to Gparted.
2. To install Puppy, click on the **Install Puppy to sdx** button located on top of the Puppy Universal Installer wizard. See Figure 2. You will then be asked if your PuppyLinux CD is in your CD-ROM drive. Press **Enter** if it is, and then choose to have syslinux installed from the next installer wizard page. An orange box will then show up on the desktop. Now you need to just press the **Enter** key for the 2 - 3 questions asked.

 **Note:** Do not use the partition tools found on PuppyLinux. In my case, Puppy Universal Installer detected the file system wrongly when created with these tools. If your pen drive is already F16 formatted, refer to Point (2) above. If not, use partitioning tools like Gparted or *cfdisk* from the Linux distribution that's installed on your hard disk, and then follow instructions in Point (2) above.

Remarks: Not easy to install. The partition tools made a mess of the filesystem. Does not install to an ext3 filesystem, in spite of the Universal installer claiming to be capable enough. Excellent selection of packages. Very easy to install additional packages. Systems administration is a cake walk. Excellent hardware detection. Persistence settings. Fabulous wallpaper and a light desktop (JWM). Download the boot floppy package from the Puppy Linux site for motherboards that do not support direct booting for the USB.

Pendrive Linux

This distribution is based on the discontinued MCNLive, a subset of Mandriva. Download the USB package from downloads.sourceforge.net/pendrivelinux/Pendrivelinux08.zip

To install, carry out the following steps:

1. Double click on the Pendrivelinux08.zip package.



Figure 2: Puppy's Universal Installer wizard

- This will open the Archive Manager and show the contents of the package. Drag and drop them onto the USB partition.
2. Open the terminal and change to the **/boot** directory (see note below) copied on the USB. Run the *bootinst.sh* script as the root user.
Login password for root is 'root' while for the guest, it is 'guest'.



Note: Pendrive Linux can only be made bootable through Windows (uggghh!). To avoid using Windows to make the drive bootable, I copied the **/boot** folder of Slax (or Goblinx) to the pen drive and then executed the *bootinst.sh* script. After that, I deleted the **/boot** folder.

Remarks: Very easy to install. Excellent selection of packages and hundreds more available through Mandriva repositories. Very easy to install additional packages. Good hardware detection borrowed from Mandriva. Persistence settings. (Default loop size is 256 MB. Larger loop size can be created by navigating to **Start→Pendrivelinux→Create persistent loop**, which only works when you choose the bootloader option 'Boot Live'. Once created, you need to use the 'Boot with Persistence Changes' bootloader option to keep your changes.) Systems administration made simple through Mandriva Control Centre. 3D Desktop (Beryl and Compiz) choices make this distribution a frontrunner for the USB.

Bottom line

Having a hard time choosing the best distribution for your pen drive? Well, I, too, am facing the same dilemma. 

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